



"The Man Who Could Rule Pakistan",
January 28, 2008

"The situation prevailing in Pakistan cannot sustain any ruler. The country has to come out of it and only then can it be ruled effectively."

CHANDER M. BHAT, on e-mail

Not to be Ruled Out

Even if PPP wins the general elections in Pakistan, it should choose the prime minister with care ("The Man Who Could Rule Pakistan", January 28). Otherwise, things will move back to square one, and in Pakistan's case, to military rule. Asif Zardari, though experienced, does not have a clean image.

S. LAKSHMI, on e-mail

Neither Zardari nor his son deserve to rule Pakistan as both of them are politically immature. They cannot match the political acumen of Zulfikar Ali Bhutto or Benazir. Their only qualification is that they are related to the Bhutto clan.

A. SRIKANTIAH, Bangalore

Zardari owes his success to two important incidents in his life: his marriage to Benazir and her death.

H.R. BAPU SATYANARAYANA,
Mysore

I don't think Zardari is the right man to rule Pakistan. Once emotions subside, the people will not accept him as their leader. As far as Bilawal is concerned, he should be left alone to complete his studies and then do what he likes.

MADHU SINGH, Ambala

The Other Side

Your comprehensive report on Zardari also contains a side bar listing charges against him ("The Man Who Could Rule Pakistan", January 28). It is important that your readers get to know where the charges against him stand. For instance, Zardari is accused of murdering his brother-in-law Mir Murtaza Bhutto. The prosecution listed some 200 witnesses but till date only 32 witnesses have been examined, none of whom have deposed against him. To delay the case, the regime did not produce him before the trial court in Karachi for

nearly three years even though the detained Zardari was in its custody and the trial court issued numerous directives for his production before it. Then in the Justice Nizam murder case, when it was registered in 1996, the list of accused did not include his name. However in May 1999, Zardari was taken out of prison and tortured in a CIA centre. He was warned against registering a complaint of torture, failing which the previous challan against the accused was cancelled and Zardari was named as an accused in the murder case. Then in the SGS-Cotecna case he was charged with receiving commissions and kick-backs in the award of a pre-shipment inspection contract and was convicted by a trial court in April 1999. However, soon tapes of conversation surfaced that showed the trial judge had received instructions from the regime on what

judgement to deliver and when. The discovery of the tapes of conversation between the judge and the accountability chief and other evidence supporting Zardari's innocence led the Supreme Court to not only overturn the conviction but also make stinging strictures against the trial judge (the bias of the trial judge floated on the surface of the record). This forced two senior judges of the bench to resign in disgrace. In the other cases mentioned, either they have not started prosecution because of lack of evidence or Zardari has been acquitted of the charges.

FARHATULLAH BABAR,
Spokesperson for Pakistan
Peoples Party, Islamabad

Meddling with the Medal

It seems the Bharat Ratna is going the film awards way ("Muddle of Honour", January 28). Every party wants its candidate to win it by hook or crook. If out of